

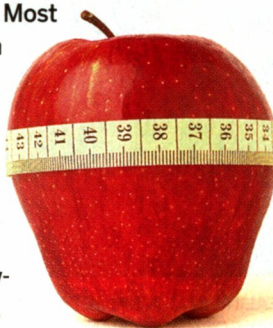


Secrets of the CENTENARIANS

People who know how to postpone the ageing process and debilitating diseases have much to tell us about how to live long and well. Kick off your new year by resolving to follow in their footsteps.

Eat Light and Stay Active

Genes play a major role in extreme longevity, but are not the only factor. Most centenarians are frugal eaters, or take low-calorie, balanced meals, high on vegetables and fruits. Less can be good, say doctors. If less food is metabolised for energy, free radicals (the "robber molecules" that are deficient in energy, and attack and snatch energy from other cells) also get reduced. Cell damage is directly linked to most of the diseases of premature ageing. But it's not just about watching your plate. Most centenarians also tend to work hard all their lives, even in their advanced ages. The lesson? Hide the TV remote, go out, stay busy, try a low-intensity workout or walking. So, moderate your habits and age healthy.



Quit Abusing Your Body

A history of substantial smoking or drinking is rare among centenarians. A lifetime of smoking or drinking subtracts an average of 10 years from your life. If you quit by age 50, you gain six of those years back.



Focus on

Family and Friends

Typically, both men and women who are 100 or older rank very high in extroversion. Most maintain a social network, have many friends and strong family ties. So, laugh lots and engage in social interaction as much as you can.

HAVE FAITH

It's not that centenarians don't face stress in life, but they have an innate ability to deal with it. Usually even-keeled people with healthy self-esteem, many of them have a strong sense of purpose, finding meaningful work till the end. Faith in a higher power is common to most. So stay away from boring or depressing people, avoid dwelling on negative events and do things that challenge your brain.

■ Compiled by **Damayanti Datta**

Think Young

Most people who live beyond 100 don't look, feel or act their chronological age. And a surprising number of centenarian women have children late in life, even after 40. A youthful attitude is an overall indication of a body that is 'ageing' slower than 'normal'. We do have a choice in our lives to decide how we are going to perceive ourselves as we get older. Avoid people who harp on your 'age' and make you feel old.

